The High Clerics of AI, Philosophy, and Physics

The Romance of the Outsider

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Paying for a Seat at the High Table

Recently, I noticed a new *Institute* being formed—one of many—with the stated aim of developing philosophy in relation to AI. I won't identify it, because it could just as easily be any such body.

On paper, you might expect this to "resonate with me". I hold a BSc, MSc, and PhD. I have been a member of multiple professional institutes. I have sat on committees, passed peer review, signed codes of conduct, and—at one time—held exactly the kind of institutional legitimacy such organisations value. But no, it didn't resonate and made me feel uncomfortable.

Why?

Over a long career in science and technology, I have come to see institutes not primarily as enablers of thought, but as **barriers**—structures that quietly claim to be more than the people within them. Their defining feature is not inquiry, but agreement. Entry requirements are formalised. Language is standardised. Presentation styles are normalised. Roles are defined. Hierarchies are inevitable.

> And always—*always*—there is a High Table.

A small group of clerics who decide what counts as serious, rigorous, respectable. I know this because I have sat there myself.

Here are some of the institutes I have been a member of:

- The Institution of Electrical Engineering (MIEE), later the Institution of Engineering and Technology (MIET)
- The Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers (MIEEE)
- The Institute of Physics and Engineering in Medicine (MIPEM)
- The Association of Gastro-Intestinal Physiologists (FAGIP)

Professionally, I was also:

- A Chartered Engineer (C.Eng)
- A State Registered Clinical Scientist (SRCS)

At one point, I could sign my name like this:

> **Which is, of course, utterly absurd.**

It tells you nothing. Those letters do not make my words more meaningful to you. They do not make my ideas more careful, more honest, or more true. Only *you* can decide the value of what I say—and that can only happen by engaging with it.

Institutes exist, in theory, to uphold standards. In practice, they uphold **consensus**. They reward fluency in an internal dialect. They filter out not just error, but also difference. Over time, it seems to me, these bodies become alien to the very people that they aim to serve and importantly, they do not sharpen thought—they smooth it. The language becomes stagnant and calcified.

Be very clear, this does not mean I reject institutes outright, they can be extremely valuable. Again, for me, standards do matter. However, I measure them very carefully. Their provenance, history, evolution, and adaptability make me pause for thought. I wonder how society, and we, can judge them as fit for purpose—especially in periods of profound change, which I feel we are now going through.

So framing our world at this moment in time needs flexibility and not rigidity. How can we frame and create new philosophical institutions when we haven't yet decided on what philosophies to include: Who is going to be the gatekeeper? Who decides who sits at the High

Table? Self selection and organisation costs, and for me, this is the issue. The cost may be to high.

> The cost of the new institute is that it will filter out the very anomalous thinking we need. The cost of my independence is that I have to earn your trust with every sentence.

We are at a point where the questions are not merely technical, but philosophical, linguistic, epistemic, and cultural. Yet "AI philosophy" institutes may find themselves doing what institutions have always done: importing old hierarchies, old incentives, and old gatekeeping mechanisms into a domain that most urgently needs openness—new language, new ideas, new philosophies, and perhaps even new mathematics.

AI and large language models are pointing to a different way of seeing meaning and representation. Anyone who has worked deeply with LLMs knows the richness of meaning they present. It's not merely stochastic. I have seen it — many of you have seen it. Even figures such as **Geoffrey Hinton** have acknowledged it.

> And yet our philosophy of language and meaning has barely flexed under this strain.

The philosopher **Thomas Kuhn** described such moments as *paradigm shifts*. He argued that they occur when measurements—what he called *anomalies*—can no longer be fitted into the framework of "normal science." At that point, the old language fails, and new conceptual structures must emerge.

As you read this, and as you interact with AI systems, you do not need to pay for a seat at the High Table to think carefully about these questions. You do not need institutional permission to ask foundational questions. And you certainly do not need a badge to notice when language is being used to substitute authority for understanding.

Kuhn also observed that some of the most important thinking during a paradigm shift comes from **outside** established structures. It has to. Institutes cannot easily question the assumptions that justify their own existence. Those operating outside “normal science” can.

Those people can ask questions that do not yet fit. They explore ideas that may not even be expressible in the old language. They build new directions of thought—still grounded in measurement and verification, but from a different perspective, a different attractor, a different basin of thought.

> That independence comes at a cost.

There is no title to hide behind. No committee to validate your tone. No clerical class to absorb responsibility for what you say. There is only this: you speak, you write, and you expose your thinking to others. Your words—and the ideas they carry—must stand or fall on their own coherence.

> This is not necessarily a structural weakness. In practice, it may be the only honest position left for a researcher and thinker.

Am I an outsider? Yes—and I openly admit I have a vested interest. Not in acquiring a seat at the High Table, but in sharing ideas and having a voice to share forward. Some of my work, grounded in the deepest thinking I can do, seems to point toward the next age of science. I do not have all the answers. But my questions are so different that the old clerics cannot—or will not—see their implications. I continue to write and I continue to work. In part because modern AI and LLMs *can* see the connections I am making.

The Romance of the Traveller

One might say I am romanticizing the outsider. And to that, I say: yes. That romance is what keeps me going. Perhaps we need that very romance. Perhaps it is this romance which has always driven science forward?

Maybe romance itself is the necessary corrective force to overcome institutional friction and not a criticism alone. Perhaps, the romance of the outsider is not a risk; it is the **engine** of the Kuhnian shift. It’s the irrational belief that one person, looking from a different angle, with different tools, might see something the whole consensus has missed.

So maybe I'm not romanticizing the outsider as a comfortable pose; but recognizing a possible role for myself as a part of the **necessary anomaly**. Consider, where institutions smooth, the outsider must be a burr. Where language standardizes, the outsider must speak a new dialect. Where consensus calcifies, the outsider must be the disequilibrium, the perturbation to shift language to a new basin of thought.

This romance, has been an engine and driving force of science. Think of the natural philosophers tinkering in their workshops, the gentleman scientists funding their own expeditions, the graduate students stumbling onto a waveform no one predicted, the programmers patching together code that suddenly *sees*. The institute formalizes the breakthrough *after* it happens. The romance, a stubborn personal and often lonely conviction, is, perhaps, what produces it. This is the spirit in which I pursue my own work on Geofinitism —a framework that, to me, feels like part of the new language required to measure this new world.

So I write not only for the present, but for the future. Perhaps even for a world in which I am no longer here. And mostly, I write for the romance—the simple and poetic idea that these words may echo into a future long after I am gone.

In the follow-up to this article, I will explore the constraints imposed by institutional knowledge itself—and what it means to write for a future intelligence that may not share our hierarchies, our incentives, or our High Tables.

> *Omne quod est, finitum est; tantum per mensuram cognosci potest*
> Everything that exists is finite; it can only be known by measure
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